

eos through dating websites or social media sites. Sometimes, they can even be prompted to perform explicit, sexual acts live on webcam. The scammers then blackmail the victims by asking them to pay a sum of money to ensure that their indecent photos and videos are not uploaded to the internet.

08 HITMAN SCAM

The scammer sends out threats of physical violence and even death while pretending to be a hitman who has been hired to hurt or kill you. In order for him to relinquish his role, you must pay a fee. Emails of this nature contain personal details, usually obtained from social media, to make them seem more threatening.

09 DDOS ATTACK

DDoS (Distributed Denial of Service) attacks resemble ransomware attacks, however, instead of encrypting data, it is often whole websites or internet services that are blocked. This happens when the attacker sends an influx of dummy traffic into the web servers hosting these sites and services, causing them to be overwhelmed. This slows down the site to a crawl where it is almost inaccessible or even completely shuts it down. Businesses are usually prime targets of DDoS attacks.

10 BANK VISHING

Bank vishing are attacks that see scammers call customers of a particular bank as financial representatives claiming that there has been certain fraudulent transactions or activity. The attacker then attempts to make the victim divulge personal information or bank account details.

11 FAKE PRIZES OR WINNINGS

Often unsuspecting people are subject to fake prizes or contest winnings texts or automated calls. These texts or calls cite that the target has won a ridiculous amount of money for something he/she has never registered. Promised prizes include lottery winnings, cash prizes, cars, all-expenses-paid vacations and

more. In reality, frauds are employing these tactics to gain access to personal information that can be used in credit card or identity theft scams.

12 INFECTED PC/VIRUS SCAM

Ever seen those pop-up ads which tell you that your device (often uses the exact model name) is infected? This pop-up usually has a number or website that you need to contact or visit. The pop-up is also extremely hard to get rid of, giving the user more incentive to actually make the call. Once the attacker is contacted, the victim is prompted to allow the 'tech support' remote access of their device. The fake tech support can then do anything with it, including installing malware, ransomware or even continue accessing the device after the issue is 'resolved'.

13 IMPERSONATION SCAM

Scammers assume the identity and create an exact replica of someone's social media page. Catfishing with these accounts is one of the most common agendas. However, more serious offences are seen too once the criminal connects to your friends and family via your duplicate account. These include spreading malware and requesting money for a variety of made-up scenarios.

14 FREE OR DISCOUNTED VACATION

Scammers capitalise on people's desire to travel by reaching out through emails or calls and telling victims that they have won a free or heavily discounted vacation. The victim must pay a seemingly small amount of money to avail this free trip or provide their credit card details. In the former, the criminal takes off with the money and in the latter, the details are used for credit card fraud.

15 FAKE TAX REFUND SCAM

This scam aims to target victims that are expecting some kind of tax refund. The criminals usually pose as the IRS or some kind of similar organisation. They prompt the victim to click through a link

which will lead them to the page that will provide them with the tax refund. However, this is actually a phishing site which will make the victim divulge their social security number or banking details, which can be used in identity theft.

16 FAKE CRYPTOCURRENCY EXCHANGES

Criminals take customers' money through questionable or fake crypto-coin exchanges. A variant is an initial coin offering (ICO) scam. GainBitcoin, DietBitcoin, OneCoin, MoneyTradeCoin, RippleFuture, NCR-Coin, ATCCoin, EB3coins, BitConnect, Kashh Coin, Gotri Pay-Way Coin and Centra Tech were all cryptocurrency scams busted in India.

17 CRYPTO MINING MALWARE

Mining cryptocurrency usually consumes a lot of computational power which isn't exactly cheap. Scammers have developed mining malware which allows them to exploit users' computational power. This malware is usually spread through a trojan. All the infected computers join together to form a botnet which mine various kinds of cryptocurrencies. Examples of mining malware are Digmine which spread through Facebook Messenger and WannaMine, which utilises EternalBlue, a leaked NSA exploit.

18 ONLINE DATING AND ROMANCE SCAMS

These scams are the oldest in the book of con artists, but as long as people are traversing the internet in search of love, they will not go away. Romance frauds may contact their targets through online dating sites, social media, email, texts or phone calls. They pose as fake individuals (catfishing) and often work in groups to extract money or personal information from the victim. Romance scams have even amounted to victims helping the criminals carry out illegal activities.

It is truly better to be safe rather than sorry in an age where everyone is living an infallibly connected life and privacy is a mere sham. 